

Frozen Shit and Old Grudges

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The fortress had no name worth remembering.

It squatted on the borderline between two territories that had been arguing about ownership for longer than anyone currently alive could recall, and the argument had produced, over the years, a wall, a ditch, a second wall, and a general atmosphere of architectural anxiety. The army experts had been hired to maintain it through the winter — which meant, in practice, re-mortaring the sections that had crumbled, deepening the ditch that had silted, patching the gate that had warped, and attending to the latrines, which had not been attended to in a manner that reflected well on anyone.

It was, by any measure, inglorious work. And sergeant Briggs was the first appointed.

Blackhoof was on his third shovelful of the morning when he paused, looked at the frozen ground, and offered his assessment.

"At least when they're frozen they don't smell as much."

Briggs, passing with a wheelbarrow and the expression of a man who had decided his feelings about the situation were not worth the energy of having them, did not break stride.

"Mm," he said.

"I'm serious. In summer this would be—"

"I know what it would be in summer." He set the wheelbarrow down with a sound that ended the conversation. "Dig."

Blackhoof dug.

The days had a rhythm to them that was almost comfortable, in the way that tedious things became comfortable when they were predictable. Mornings: walls, ditches, gates, latrines. Afternoons: more of the same, or training if the weather permitted, which it usually didn't. Evenings: fire, food, and the specific relief of horizontal surfaces.

It was in the evenings that Blackhoof had learned how to ask questions. Start talking about something else, let the conversation find its own level, and wait. It was, Blackhoof had come to understand, the same technique Briggs used at cards. Patience as strategy.

One day he made up his mind and bit a rotten apple.

They were at the fire, the fortress wall dark behind them, the cold doing its usual work on everything exposed. Briggs had his flask. Blackhoof had his portion of the evening meal, which was warm and one level above *edible*.

"Biggs," he said, in the tone of someone raising a topic casually.

"Mm."

"Tusk."

A pause. Brief, but present.

"What about him."

"He doesn't like you."

"No."

"Has he ever liked you?"

Briggs looked at the fire. He took a pull from the flask and held it for a moment before answering, with the expression of a man deciding how much of a door to open.

"There was a battle," he said finally. "Spring campaign. Two, maybe three years ago."

Blackhoof said nothing. He had learned that silence was the correct response here — the moment you expressed enthusiasm, Briggs closed like a shutter.

"We'd been hired to clear a swamp. Bullywugs — their territory, technically, but someone had decided it was in the way of something more profitable." He paused. "We went in. They were ready for us. More of them than the briefing suggested, and they knew every inch of ground." He looked at the fire. "Wet ground. Rain for three weeks. Goblins don't fight well in mud."

"And bullywugs do," Blackhoof said.

"They were born in it." He shrugged, a small economical movement. "The line broke. It happens. Men running in directions they hadn't planned to run, which is how you end up with your supply officer cornered against a tree with a bullywug sitting on him."

Something moved in Blackhoof's face.

"Tusk," he said.

"Tusk." Briggs drank again. "First time he'd been anywhere near actual fighting, I expect. He had his ledger in one hand and a short sword in the other and absolutely no idea what to do with either."

"And you—"

"I was there." Flat. "With Ironhoof."

The name landed with a particular weight. Blackhoof had heard it before, just once, in the clearing in the forest, in the broken-open voice of a man who thought he was talking to ghosts. He did not pursue it now.

"Ironhoof pulled the bullywug off him," Briggs continued. "I put it down. That was the whole of it. Six seconds."

"And Tusk?"

Briggs was quiet for a moment. The fire shifted.

"He stood up," he said. "Straightened his coat. Looked at us—" Something moved briefly in his expression. "Like we'd done something to him. Not something for him. To him." He paused. "I didn't understand it at the time. I didn't think about it much."

"He was ashamed," Blackhoof said.

"I know that now." He turned the flask in his hands. "Then I just thought he was strange."

Blackhoof looked at the fire for a moment. "Were they really a threat? The bullywugs?" He paused. "Or were we just — in their home?"

Briggs looked at him sideways.

"Don't," he said.

"I'm just asking."

"You're asking something you already know the answer to." He pulled his coat tighter. "I stopped working for causes a long time ago, Blacky. I work for payment. What the payment is for—" he gestured vaguely at the dark, at the fortress, at the frozen latrine ditch somewhere behind them — "is someone else's business."

Blackhoof thought about this for a moment. He thought about saying something further and decided against it, which Briggs would have called growth.

They sat in the quiet for a while, the fortress wall blocking the worst of the wind.

"Is that it? Doesn't seem like the whole thing." Blackhoof said eventually.

Briggs looked at him.

But that evening reached its end.

A new day was born and Blackhoof was neighing since the dawn. That day they have been digging the ditch. Briggs commanded three goblins, three centaurs were pulling the carts. One completely happy about the drought position, one completely out in his inner world and Blackhoof - with an idea nagging him the whole day. Briggs saw it, saw the looks, he could literally hear the squeaking sound of Blackhoof's thoughts.

When they sit by the fire that evening, Briggs was not in a good mood. And he knew, it won't get any better. That enthusiastic boy will not let him be.

"You said Tusk is not playing dice with you. Never." He chose his words. "But it sounds like he did - at least once...?"

A longer pause this time.

"That was a different occasion," Briggs said. "Also several years ago."

"Was it?"

Briggs looked at the centaur for a short time, then he turned to the fire with the expression of a man who had walked toward a door and found it already open and was now committed to the direction.

"Summer camp," he said. "Somewhere flat. The kind of evening where there's nothing to do and everyone knows it." He reached into his coat and produced the twelve-sided die —

worn smooth, the numbers faint — and turned it in his fingers. "Game got going. Tusk sat down."

Blackhoof was literally trembling with curiosity, but held his lips sealed. "He knew the rules. He did not know the wits." He paused. "I did not know, at the time, that he was—" He stopped. Started again. "He had a whole week's wages on the table by the third round. I didn't pay much attention to that."

"Because you were winning."

"Because I was playing." He set the die down on his knee. "By the end of the evening he had nothing left. I had a considerable amount of his money." Quiet for a moment. "He got up from that table and he walked away and I watched him go and thought—" he paused — "nothing, really. I thought nothing. The game was done. But now, I think it may have some consequences."

"Like?" Blackhoof looked at him.

"He had to eat at the common pot," Briggs said. "For a week. No supplementary rations, no private stores. Same food as every line soldier, same bench, same bowl." He turned the die over once more. "Tusk is a man who considers himself — distinct. From line soldiers." He looked at the fire. "A week of not being distinct, in front of everyone who had watched him lose."

"You didn't mean to humiliate him," Blackhoof said. It was not quite a question.

"I meant to win," Briggs said. "Which I did. What that meant to him—" He stopped. Set the die back in his coat pocket. The fire crackled. Somewhere inside the fortress, someone was playing something on a stringed instrument, badly, with great conviction.

"A few months back -do you think Tusk knew?" he said. "About the delivery. That the route was watched."

Briggs was quiet for a long time.

"I think," he said finally, "that Tusk is a man who arranges things. Supply lines, inventories, information. Maybe he arranged it outside of usual ways."

"So you can't prove it."

"No."

"But you know."

"Suspect."

"Anyway you have to be careful with every task he gives you."

"Why'd you think that? He is a professional - we both are."

"Yes, but he's a professional with a grudge against you."

"I think you're paranoid."

They sat with that for a while. The fire burned between them, and the cold did its patient work on everything outside the circle of warmth, and neither of them said anything else, and it was, all things considered, a fine enough evening for a frozen fortress on a border that nobody particularly cared about.

"Tomorrow," said centaur, "it's the south ditch."

"I know," said Briggs.

"I checked. It's not frozen."

A pause.

"Go to sleep, Blacky," said Briggs.

Blackhoof went to sleep, smiling.

